

Course Code and Name: MSJ2252 Digital Audience

Project Name: Reflection Paper

Semester: Spring 2026

Project Description: For the Digital Audience course in the Spring 2026 semester at the University of Liberal Arts Bangladesh (ULAB), I completed an academic reflection paper titled "New Gatekeepers: How Audiences are Reshaping Journalism in Bangladesh." Based on a guest lecture and qualitative analysis, the paper explored how digital audiences increasingly influence newsroom decisions and challenge traditional media gatekeeping. It examined the relationship between audience engagement, court reporting, investigative journalism, and ethical news production in Bangladesh. By reflecting on real legal reporting experiences and current media practices, the project highlighted the need to balance public interest, audience demand, and journalistic responsibility. Overall, the study strengthened my understanding of digital journalism, media ethics, and the evolving role of audiences in today's news environment.

Project Justification: This project explores how digital audiences are reshaping journalism in Bangladesh by influencing newsroom decisions and media priorities. I chose this topic after attending a guest lecture that demonstrated the real impact of ethical court reporting and investigative journalism on people's lives. The study examines the challenge of balancing audience demand for fast, engaging content with the responsibility to report important legal and social issues accurately. It highlights the importance of ethical journalism, investigative reporting, and people-centered storytelling in the digital age. Through this reflection, I hope to encourage greater appreciation for responsible journalism that gives a voice to marginalized communities while maintaining professional integrity and public trust.

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Course Title: Digital Audience

Date: April 15, 2026

Topic: New Gatekeepers: How Audiences are Reshaping Journalism in Bangladesh

Guest Speaker: Masudur Rahman Rana, Special Correspondent, Channel 24

Summary of Key Points

In his discussion, Masudur Rahman Rana, Special Correspondent of Channel 24, explained a major change in modern journalism. He showed how the power of “gatekeeping,” or controlling news, has shifted from editors to audiences. Based on his experience in court reporting, he explained that audiences today are more interested in sensational news such as final verdicts, death sentences, or bail decisions. Audience behavior and demand now strongly influence what news is produced. However, beyond this commercial pressure, he also showed how investigative journalism can give a voice to people who are denied justice.

Critical Analysis

Digital platforms and direct audience participation have changed how news is presented. Audiences are no longer just receivers of news; they are decision-makers. According to Rana, media organizations tend to focus on what audiences want to see. In court reporting, this creates a challenge because people prefer quick outcomes rather than understanding the full legal process.

Media now follows digital footprints like views and engagement. As a result, deep investigative work is often ignored. However, Rana demonstrated that skilled journalists can still find meaningful human stories. For example, he mentioned family cases involving land disputes or even Facebook passwords, showing the strange but real nature of society. In Bangladesh, about one in seven people is involved in land-related cases, which often continue for generations. Solving these issues requires strong investigative work, which is sometimes lost in view-driven journalism.

Personal Reflection and Examples

The stories of “Babul” and “Islam and Mala” deeply affected me. Especially the case where Islam spent 17 years in prison without proper justice shows the power of journalism. It was a rape case, and after 17 years, they were finally allowed to marry through a humane court decision. When the speaker shared the father’s regret and the emotional reunion, it highlighted

the human responsibility of journalism.

As a future journalist, this session changed my perspective. One important lesson was his statement: “A journalist must wake up early in the morning,” which reflects professionalism. I also learned that court journalism is not just about reporting hearings; it requires strong relationships with lawyers and understanding legal terms and patterns. His report during the COVID-19 period about the silence of the Supreme Court taught me that creativity is possible even in difficult situations.

Legal Limitations and Reality

Bangladesh currently has about 4.7 million pending cases, which may reach 7 million in the coming years. Due to a lack of judges, delays in investigation, and political pressure, people suffer in the legal system. Rana clearly stated that no government has been able to reduce this backlog effectively. Journalists must work within these limitations. A good court reporter must understand every stage of a case, from investigation and charge sheet to witness examination and trial.

Conclusion

Although audience demand is reshaping journalism, the importance of ethical journalism remains strong. In fact, in the digital age, the need for investigative journalism has increased. Rana’s experience shows that journalism is not just about sharing information but also about exposing problems in society and the state. In the future, maintaining journalistic independence and addressing legal delays will require stronger media involvement. Protecting people’s rights through ethical journalism should be our main goal.

Project Learnings and Outcomes: This project strengthened my research, analytical, and academic writing skills by teaching me how to critically evaluate media issues and connect theoretical concepts with real-world journalism practices. It improved my ability to analyze expert opinions, organize qualitative information, and develop well-structured academic reflections. Through this work, I gained a deeper understanding of digital audience behavior, media gatekeeping, court reporting, and the ethical responsibilities of journalists in the digital age. The project also enhanced my critical thinking by helping me examine the relationship between audience preferences, newsroom decision-making, human rights, and investigative journalism. Overall, this experience made me a more thoughtful, ethical, and socially responsible media communicator, better prepared to balance audience engagement with accurate, meaningful, and public-interest journalism.